Player of our Heartstrings

No instrumentalist has done for their instrument what Pandit Shivkumar Sharma did for the santoor

By Pt. Hariprasad Chaurasia

It was in 1958 that Shiv*ji* and I met for the first time in Delhi's Talkatora Stadium. I remember we were both there for an inter-collegiate meet, he as a participant and me as an accompanist. Even though we were friendly then, we truly became friends a few months later when I met him in Bombay. At that point, he'd just finished his education in Jammu and had come to Bombay looking for work. Since he could play both the santoor and the tabla, he had an ear for *swara* (chords) and also *lay* (rhythm).

Bombay is like a great ocean. It's a city you can easily get lost in. The thing about Shiv*ji*, however, was that he was so nice and noble, and, also, so well-educated, that it didn't take long for his music to reach audiences. He was loved by people almost instantly. I honestly have no words to describe his talent. We started hearing the santoor because of his courage. It was always thought of as a folk instrument, but it was through Shiv*ji* that people began to love and respect it as a classical instrument.

Call of the Valley, the first album we released together in 1967, was Shiv*ji*'s idea. The theme of this record—one day in the life of a Kashmiri shepherd—had also come from him. The album became very popular and I think it was this popularity which helped his santoor and my bansuri form their own respective identities in the minds of our audiences. At that time, we were playing classical concerts and also playing for films. A few years later, when Yash Chopra asked us to give music for his films, we both took it as a challenge. If someone was saying we should do something, we at least had to try. I had never thought that we'd be running in so many directions, but audiences liked what Shiv-Hari did.

We had some common passions. We both loved food, for instance—vegetarian and non-vegetarian. But we, of course, didn't have the same blood or the same mind. It's just that when we would sit down to think about music, there would be a rare synthesis. He would like what I did, and I would like what he did. At one level, it felt like it was this union of spirits. That is what gave us the confidence we had.

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In the end, I can only say there is no precedent for what he had done with the santoor. People might think that now because he isn't there, the santoor will perish. But that's like saying the Taj Mahal should have fallen without Shah Jahan. Future generations who have liked and supported him, it's they who will make sure that the santoor will continue to prosper, not just in India but the world over. ■

(as told to Shreevatsa Nevatia)

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HIGH NOTES

Some of Pandit Shivkumar Sharma's career milestones

- Born on January 13, 1938, Shivkumar Sharma was only five when his father Uma Dutt Sharma started giving him vocal and tabla lessons. Growing up, his favourite pieces of music were Ustad Bade Ghulam Ali Khan's renditions of Kedar and Jaijaivanti
- Sharma was 12 when he started learning the santoor; in 1955, he gave his first live performance. The one-hour-long rendition of Raga Yaman left his audience in Mumbai shouting 'Encore!'
- In 1955, Sharma even composed the background music for one of the scenes in V. Shantaram's blockbuster hit, *Jhanak Jhanak Payal Baje*
- In 1960, a 22-year-old Sharma left Jammu for Bombay, determined to make a career in music
- *Call of the Valley* (1967), the first album Sharma and flautist Hariprasad Chaurasia released together, became HMV's bestselling classical record in India
- Sharma's 1968 concert in Los Angeles was his first performance abroad. He followed this with a tour of England in 1970
- The duo Shiv-Hari went on to score music for eight films, seven of which were directed by Yash Chopra. These included *Silsila* (1981), *Chandni* (1989) and *Lamhe* (1991)
- In 1996, Sharma and his son Rahul played the santoor on a Norway stage as "equals" for the first time
- Sharma was awarded the Padma Shri in 1991 and the Padma Bhushan in 2001

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